Joanne Little

Copyright - March, 1975
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Refrain and Chorus:

Who is this Girl ? And what is she to you?

Joanne Little -- She's my Sister
Joanne Little -- She's Our Mama
Joanne Little -- She's Your Lover
Joanne's the Woman whose gonna carry your child

Verse I:

I've always been told since the day I was born
Leave them no-good Women alone
Keep your nose clean Keep your butt off the street
You gon' be judged by the company you keep
I've always walked by the golden rule
Steered clear of controversy I stayed real cool
Till along came this Woman - Little over five feet tall
Charged and jailed with breaking the law
the next thing I heard as it come over the news
1st degree murder -- she was on the loose

Refrain + Chorus:

Verse II:

Now I ain't talking about the roaring west
this is 1975 at it's most oppressive best
North Carolina State the pride of this land
Made her an Outlaw hunted on every hand
What did she do to deserve this name
Killed a man who thought that she was fair game
When I heard the news I screamed inside
Lost all my cool my anger I could not hide
Cause now -- Joanne is you and Joanne is me
Our prison is the whole society
We live in a land that brings all pressure to bear
On the head of this Woman whose position we share

Refrain + Chorus:

the song "Joanne Little" addresses the fact that in our society prison tends to separate those on the inside from those on the outside. Especially from "respectable" members of our ~~[illegible]~~ community -- we get "stay out of the wrong places -- with the wrong people and you will stay out of trouble." One gets little support for associating with "the wrong kind". Brothers and sisters -- like Joanne Little are in the "wrong" place, with the "wrong" crowd and that's why they are in trouble -- or so goes the wagging tongues.

I tried to say in this song that I would not allow the powers that be confuse me on this issue. Joanne Little is a member of my family -- She is getting fucked over and I don't like it!

Bernice Reagon
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Toronto, Canada